

Malaysian orchid mantis

Hymenopus coronatus

With its fine pink and cream shading, this mantis is a master of disguise. It resembles a forest orchid, with the back legs flattened to look like petals, and the plump abdomen resembling a ripening bud. The trick this insect plays not only keeps it hidden from predators that might snatch it from plants, but also fools its prey, which fly straight to it thinking it is a nectar-filled bloom.

Killer mimic

This strategy is known as aggressive mimicry. The Malaysian orchid mantis climbs around a plant until it finds a cluster of flowers. It can fine-tune its color from pink to brown to match its location, making it indistinguishable even when viewed in the ultraviolet spectrum by its insect prey. The mantis sways with the flimsy blooms, making it even harder to spot. Pollinating insects appear to approach the mantis as frequently as they do the real flowers—and are snatched up with lightning speed.

↔ 1-2 in (3-5 cm)

✕ Not known

🦋 Insects

🏠 

SE. Asia

▷ **GRABBING FORELIMBS**
The mantis catches prey with its raptorial forelegs—sometimes snatching them from midair. The legs are lined with spikes to grip its victims.

fleshy, budlike abdomen

hornlike eyes

The orchid mantis can match the colors of 13 flowers that live in its habitat

